

November Assessment Study List - Armstrong

	Not really	I need more work	I'm ready
Drama			
Can I summarise the key moments in the play?			✓
Can I talk about how the key moments affected the main characters?			✓
Can I talk about how the relationships between the main characters are affected or highlighted by the key moments?			✓
Can I describe the traits of the main characters?			✓
Can I define soliloquy, dramatic irony and foreshadowing?			✓
How can lights, costume and set be used to improve the audience's enjoyment?		✓	
The benefits of a modern version vs a traditional version		✓	
Can I read and understand a short passage of Shakespeare?			✓
Spelling and Grammar			
Can I identify spelling and grammar errors in a sentence?			✓

Tips for Writing an Essay

- Always read the question carefully.** Highlight or underline the most important parts of the question. The quickest way to lose marks is by not answering exactly what is asked of you.
- Plan your answer:** Spend two minutes planning out your answer. Decide which key moments, characters or themes you will discuss in your answer. Try to write a one or two word description of each paragraph before you begin so you know which way you should write your answer.
- Write a very short introduction.** This could be as simple as 'The play I have studied is William Shakespeare's 'The Merchant of Venice'. Make sure you spell 'Shakespeare' correctly and that you use quotation marks for the title - 'The Merchant of Venice'.
- Every 5 marks deserves one paragraph.** If you are answering a 20 mark question, you should try to write four paragraphs. Each paragraph should make its own point/argument.

5. **Stick to the recommending timings.** If you are not finished a question but you're about to go over the recommended time - move on to the next question. You are likely to get more marks in the next question than the few marks you could gain by trying to perfect the other answer.
6. **Use PQE (or PIE) in for every paragraph.** Each paragraph should begin with a statement, and the rest of your paragraph should focus on explaining that statement.
7. **Use quotes.** Use one or two relevant quotes per paragraph to support your answer. The quotes will prove that you are right. Do not use too many quotes in a single paragraph - this will stop you from creating your own original analysis of the play.
8. **Avoid summarising the whole play.** Just focus on key moments and how those key moments changed a character.
9. **Quality over quantity.** You will only have a limited amount of time to write your answer so it will not be perfect. Your goal is to express your writing ability and knowledge of the text in an exam environment. Show off your vocabulary
10. **Answer the question.** The easiest way to prove you are answering the question is to repeat the question in your answer.
11. **Act confident.** Use phrases that convince the examiner you are correct. I've attached a number of examples at the end of this page.
12. **Avoid using 'I', unless the question is looking for you to share your opinion.**
13. **Believe in yourself.** You have all been working really, really hard this year and you should have every confidence in yourself.

Sample Question and Answer

- (a) Using a play or a novel you have studied, describe one key moment when a strong relationship is apparent between two characters.
- (b) Do you think both of the characters benefitted equally from this relationship? Explain your answer using your chosen text as support.

Planning your answer

Note that this question has two parts, (a) and (b). With questions like this, read the two parts first, so that you can plan and write your answer carefully for each part. This will help prevent you from writing material in part (a) that could be more suitable for part (b). When revising your novels and Shakespearean play, it is important to keep revisiting key moments such as:

- Moments that tell us much about a character's strengths and weaknesses
- Moments that show a change in a character's fortunes or woes
- Moments when a character's fate is sealed

- Moments that highlight key themes
- Moments that are climatic or create a turning point in the text.

The opening and ending are usually important key moments too.

While it is important to have a strong, overall knowledge and understanding of your novels and Shakespearean play, select at least 5-6 key moments and ensure that you know them in detail.

Part A

The sample answer for part (a) looks at the strong relationship that exists between Antonio and Bassanio in the **opening scene** of Shakespeare's play, *The Merchant of Venice*. The answer needs to provide a strong description of their relationship, using evidence from the opening scene. Refer to specific moments in the opening scene that show how Antonio supports Bassanio. Some short, bite-size quotes will help strengthen your points. Use a variety of suitable adjectives to describe their relationship.

Plan:

- Introduction: Outline the context of the relationship - Antonio always loans money to his friend, Bassanio. Antonio is a generous friend, while Bassanio is a spendthrift and adventurous character.
- In this key moment, Antonio has no money to lend, but offers to be the guarantor of a loan, so that his friend can travel to Belmont to partake in Portia's casket test. Antonio is always there to unconditionally support his friend.

Part B

Part (b) of the question is a little more challenging. It ~~is~~ asks you to decide if the characters in the relationship benefitted equally. While there might be equity in some relationships, the relationship between Antonio and Bassanio is not one where each character benefits equally. Bassanio gains much from his friendship with Antonio. Crucially, Antonio's raising of a loan for Bassanio allows him to travel to Belmont, where he wins the casket test, enabling him to marry the wealthy Portia. Antonio nearly loses his life in the process.

In this answer, you need to make an argument that Bassanio benefits more from his relationship with Antonio. To make your argument, you need to refer to moments in the play that show Bassanio benefitting more so than Antonio. Using some suitable quotes from the play will help strengthen your argument.

Plan:

- Bassanio successfully selects the right casket and wins Portia in marriage. He instantly becomes a rich man and all his financial woes are over. By contrast, his friend Antonio's life is at risk, as he is unable to repay the loan to Shylock.
- While Bassanio tries to help save Antonio, it is his wife, Portia disguised as Balthazar who saves Antonio.
- Antonio's fortunes and finances improve after he is saved, but he still remains single and lonely. Bassanio is now financially better off. However, Antonio helped facilitate Bassanio's success by securing the loan.

Sample Answer

(a)

In William Shakespeare's 'The Merchant of Venice', there is a strong relationship between two of the play's most significant characters, Antonio and Bassanio. The strength of their relationship is particularly evident in Act I, scene 1. Antonio is a wealthy merchant, and all his money is tied up in ships at sea. Bassanio is a spendthrift and adventurous character, who has always relied on Antonio's generosity. In this key moment, Bassanio yet again asks his dearest friend, Antonio for another loan, so that he can woo Portia.

Despite Bassanio's failure to repay all his previous loans, such is Antonio's affection for Bassanio that he tells him, 'be assured/ My purse, my person, my extremest means/ Lie all unlocked to your occasions.' Antonio has always shown unwavering loyalty and support for his friend. Bassanio acknowledges this when he admits, 'To you, Antonio,/ I owe the most in money and in love ...' In this scene, Antonio shows his unconditional support for Bassanio, as he instructs him to raise whatever money he can from moneylenders in Venice, and he promises to act as the guarantor of the loan. This is a risky undertaking for Antonio as he admits that 'all my fortunes are at sea;/ Neither have I money nor commodity/ To raise a present sum.' Moreover, Bassanio has never repaid any previous loans, yet like a true friend, Antonio wants to help his friend fulfil his ambitions and make his dreams come true. Antonio supports Bassanio's plan to hopefully marry Portia, and in turn end all his financial woes.

There is clearly a very strong relationship between Antonio and Bassanio, as Antonio is always ready to unconditionally support his friend, and Bassanio knows he can rely on his support no matter what happens.

(b)

Bassanio benefitted more from the relationship. Firstly, before he attempted to woo Portia, Bassanio was able to live an extravagant lifestyle due to the financial support he received from Antonio. Moreover, Antonio put the funds in place to enable Bassanio to travel to Belmont and successfully complete the casket test, allowing him to win Portia in marriage. However, the relationship is not parasitic, as Bassanio clearly cares about Antonio and is desperately anxious to save Antonio from death, when he is unable to repay his debt. He is genuinely worried for his friend, recognising that he has engaged himself to a dear friend, and in turn, engaged his 'friend to his mere enemy,' so as to feed his means (Act 3, scene 2). Furthermore, Bassanio acknowledges that Antonio is 'the dearest friend to me, the kindest man,/ The best-conditioned and unwearied spirit in doing courtesies ...'

With Bassanio's marriage to Portia, his fortunes multiply, and he instantly becomes a very wealthy man. At the same moment, Antonio is about to lose everything. He has received dreadful news leading him to believe that all his ships have been wrecked at sea. His inability to repay Shylock means that he will have to forfeit his life. At this particular point in the play, Antonio's life is at stake, all because he promised to act as guarantor for Bassanio's loan. He has certainly benefitted in no way from his relationship with Bassanio, for he writes: 'Sweet Bassanio, my ships have all miscarried, my creditors grow cruel, my estate is very low, my bond to the Jew is forfeit, and, since in paying it, it is impossible I should live ...' His support for Bassanio has endangered his life, yet he holds no anger or bitterness, for he writes 'all debts are cleared between you and I if I might but see you at my death.'

However, with the clever and skilful intervention of Portia (disguised as Balthazar), Antonio's life is saved and he gains half of Shylock's wealth as compensation, which he gives to Lorenzo and Jessica. Towards the end of the play, Portia also brings Antonio the good news that 'three of your argosies/ are richly come to harbour suddenly' (Act 5, scene 1, lines 275-76).

Bassanio gains a wife and becomes a wealthy man by the end of the play. Antonio's support has helped him achieve this. Antonio still remains a wealthy man at the end of the play; however, he has not gained a wife like his friend, Bassanio, and to an extent, his life remains lonely. For that reason, I think Bassanio has benefitted more from the relationship. Bassanio showed his loyalty and support for Antonio when his life was at risk; however, he did not have the capabilities to save him. It was his wife in disguise who actually rescued Antonio from death.